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HINDUSTAN TIMES

PITCHED BATTLE (Left) Bhupinder Singh Hooda takes stock in Chandigarh; Khattar with CM Nayab Singh Saini

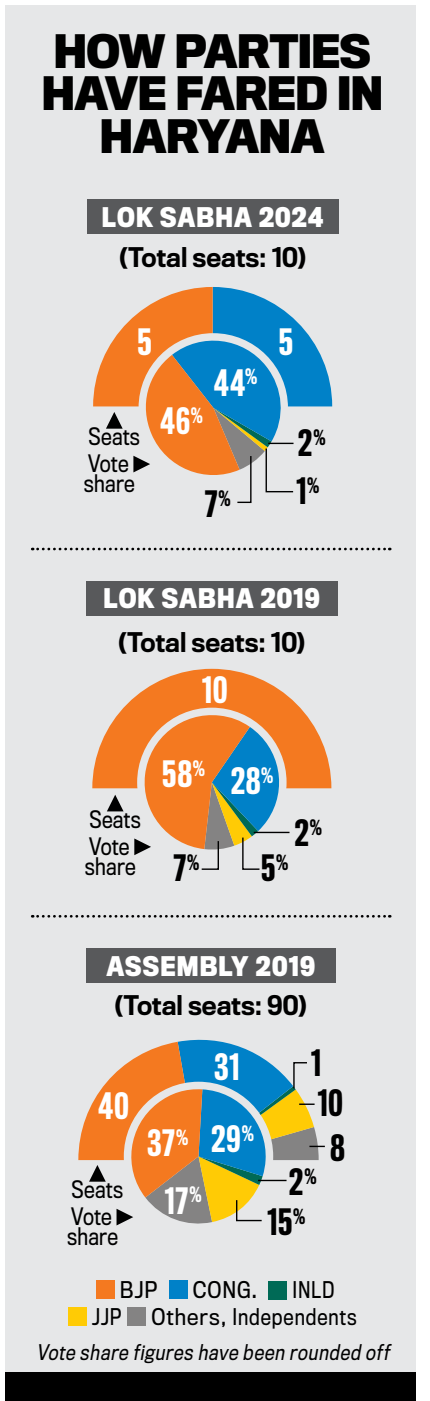
he'd done with his innovative crop pricing policies that benefitted all and the robust 8.1 per cent agricultural growth Haryana posted in FY24 consequently. The drop in fondness for the BJP among the Jats, an agrarian community that comprises 27 per cent of the populace and had hitherto been Modi enthusiasts, was fairly steep. A Lokniti-CSDS (Centre for the Study of Developing Societies) post-poll survey estimated that 63 per cent of the Jats voted for the Congress compared to 2019, when nearly half the community went with the BJP. This left the BJP with only one of the five seats in Jat-dominated areas: Bhiwani-Mahendragarh. The rest swung the Congress way.

Enter Khattar acolyte Saini, whose native, agrarian, non-Jat OBC roots make him potentially a better fit for repair work than his mentor—a bachelor RSS *pracharak* from an urban Punjabi Khatri family, anything but an organically-harvested Haryana politician. With little hope of turning around the Jat vote before the polls in the absence of a Jat leader, the BJP is concentrating on consolidating the non-Jat OBC vote, which it is hoping Saini will help them achieve. That he will lead them into the assembly election was made clear by Union home minister Amit Shah in Panchkula on June 29. Saini is the first OBC chief minister of the state, barring the 241-day stint of Rao Birendra Singh in 1967, whose son, Union minister Rao Inderjit Singh, is now a claimant for Saini's job. Having won the Gurgaon seat, Inderjit believes he is the right man to help the BJP consolidate support in south Haryana, from where it got three of its five Lok Sabha seats—Faridabad, Gurgaon and Bhiwani-Mahendragarh—besides Kurukshetra and Karnal in the north. However, Shah's backing of Saini has put paid to Inderjit's hopes.

But Saini's task is still far from easy. It isn't just the Jat vote that deserted the BJP this time, the party's Dalit base took a hit too, declining from 58 per cent in 2019 to 24 per cent this time, according to the Lokniti-CSDS survey results. The Congress seems to have prised loose the BJP hold among even the caste elite, namely the Brahmins, Baniyas, Rajputs and Punjabi Khatris, shaving eight percentage points off the BJP's 74 per cent vote share, as well as among the Block B backward communities such as the Gujjars, Ahir-Yadavs et al, trimming its vote share from 73 per cent in 2019 to 44 per cent now, going by Lokniti-CSDS data. The contest in Haryana has become a bipolar one as the out-migration of the JJP, INLD and BSP vote all accrued to the Congress.

A resurgent Hooda is intent on building on this momentum. On a month-long statewide "workers' conference", he intends to tell constituents about the party's poll guarantees and rake up issues such as unemployment, inflation, farmers' protests, the Agnipath scheme as well as the Parivar Pehchan Patra where a family identity card made mandatory for college admissions created a nightmare for

HOW PARTIES HAVE FARED IN HARYANA



Vote share figures have been rounded off